

Q At what point in my menstrual cycle should we have sex in order to get pregnant?

The best way to maximize your chances is to have sex regularly—every two to three days throughout the month—but if you want you can also try tracking your ovulation.

You are most likely to conceive in the five to six days leading up to and including ovulation (when your body releases an egg). This is called the “fertile window.” Aside from charting your monthly cycle, there are a few ways to figure out when you might be ovulating.

Monitor your cervical mucus

Just before the fertile window, a sticky, thick, cloudy white mucus appears. It turns thinner, clearer, and stretchy at ovulation. After ovulation, the mucus decreases and disappears. To check the mucus, wash your hands and insert your fingers into your vagina or wipe yourself

with toilet paper. Stretch the mucus between your fingers. Note the color and consistency.

Use an ovulation predictor kit

An ovulation kit helps predict your fertile window by measuring levels of luteinizing hormone (LH), the hormone that releases your egg. You simply test your urine to detect LH surges up to two days before ovulation, which is useful if you have an irregular cycle.

Measure your basal temperature

Your basal body temperature (BBT) changes throughout the month. Before ovulation, your

BBT is usually about 96–98°F (35–37°C). Just after ovulation, the progesterone released into the body raises your body temperature slightly (approximately 0.4°F/0.2°C) until your next period. So you can determine when ovulation has happened, but not predict it, using BBT.

If you chart your temperature changes over a few months, you may see a pattern forming of when ovulation is likely. Buy a special basal body thermometer from a pharmacy. Note your temperature at the same time every morning before you eat or drink.

There are a lot of apps available for monitoring your monthly cycle.

CHANGES DURING THE MENSTRUAL CYCLE

This graph shows a 28-day menstrual cycle and the changes that help predict the fertile window, which is in the middle of the cycle and lasts five to six days. If your menstrual cycle is not 28 days long (most are between 21 and 35 days), the fertile window will still fall roughly in the middle.

